

Tallinn: Fare-free Public Transportation (FFPT) Programme

A Research Project Analysing Tallinn's FFPT Approach to Sustainable Development



(Image – Tallinn City Government, n.d.)

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Introduction

Sustainable Development Goal 11.2 calls on cities to provide affordable, accessible, and sustainable transport for all. Fare-free public transport (FFPT) removes the cost barrier to transit entirely. On the surface, this seems like a direct answer to that goal. Currently, nearly 300 localities worldwide have adopted some form of fare-free public transport (Kębłowski, 2023). Tallinn, Estonia, was among the first major cities to adopt this approach. It eliminated fares for all registered residents and positioned itself as a self-proclaimed "Capital of Free Public Transport." Yet research has shown that, while the programme improved mobility for disadvantaged groups, car traffic increased and the environmental goals that justified the policy remain largely unmet. After providing context on the programme, this paper will argue that Tallinn's FFPT uses the language of sustainable development to legitimise what is fundamentally a fiscal and political project. It will further show how this "greening" approach to sustainable development prioritises economic metrics over ecological outcomes, relies on techno-managerial solutions, and ultimately delivers social benefits while leaving car dependency intact.

Project Background

The City of Tallinn, with approximately 420,000 residents at the time, introduced the FFPT policy on January 1, 2013 (Cats et al., 2017). The programme's stated goals varied across sources and timeframes. City officials emphasised reducing car emissions and improving mobility for disadvantaged groups (ERR News, 2012), while later research accounts added stimulating local consumption and increasing registered residents to boost municipal tax income (Hess, 2017; Cats et al., 2017). These goals are not traceable to official documents from before the programme launched, suggesting they were applied retroactively to justify a decision already made (Hess, 2017). At the time of FFPT implementation, Tallinn was a participant in CIVITAS MIMOSA, an EU-funded programme promoting sustainable urban mobility across European cities. This association lent the policy a connection to European sustainability goals, though the decision to eliminate fares did not originate from the project (Gabaldón-Estevan et al., 2019).

Before fare elimination, Tallinn's public transport was already well-used but in decline. It held a 40% mode share, though car ownership had more than doubled since Estonia's independence. Yet, fares were not the obvious problem. A single bus ride in Tallinn cost just €1, and 60% of riders already paid reduced fares or nothing at all. As such, ticket sales covered only a third of the transport operating costs (Cats et al., 2017). Nevertheless, a 2010 municipal survey found that fares were still the most common source of dissatisfaction within public transport at 49%, ahead of crowding and frequency (Cats et al., 2017). Given these conditions, fare dissatisfaction may have reflected broader frustration with the transport system rather than a genuine financial barrier. With most riders already paying little or nothing, it is not clear that removing fares would be enough to reverse declining ridership or draw drivers out of their cars.

Project Analysis

Tallinn positioned the implementation of fare-free public transport as a step toward becoming European Green Capital, framing fare elimination as a brave sustainability intervention (Aas, 2013). Yet this framing is characteristic of a "greening" approach to sustainable development (Bina, 2013). Specifically, FFPT policy focuses on refining the means of a system rather than questioning its ends. In Tallinn's case, the means being refined is the price of accessing public transport, while the ends, the dominance of car-based mobility, remain unchallenged. By treating the fare rather than the infrastructure, spatial patterns, and cultural habits that produce car dependency as the problem, the programme fixes the paradigm rather than shifting it. The following sections examine how this paradigm-fixing logic shaped the programme's political origins, distributional outcomes, technological design, and global spread.

Political Origins

Despite the project's sustainable framing, examining how FFPT policy was introduced in Tallinn reveals that sustainability was not the driving concern. The plan was announced by Mayor Savisaar in the tabloid *Õhtuleht* in January 2012, taking transport officials by surprise (Kębłowski et al., 2019). The programme had no basis in existing transport strategies and bypassed Tallinn's own 10-year Public Transport Development Strategy (Hess, 2017). As such, the plan excluded the expertise that would have complicated it. Specifically, consulting transport planners would have raised the need for congestion pricing and parking reform, measures shown to be more effective at achieving modal shift and reducing car dependency (Hess, 2017). As Banister (2008) argues, sustainable mobility requires combining pull measures like improved public transport with push measures that make driving less attractive. Tallinn's FFPT programme is a pull-only intervention that made public transport free without making driving any harder.

Furthermore, in an attempt to show the role of community participation in decision-making, city officials put the FFPT policy to a public vote, which was held in March 2012 (Kębłowski et al., 2019). Yet the vote was non-binding with just 15% turnout, preceded by a campaign in city-owned media and the suspension of fares on voting days. As one official admitted, "this is exactly what the referendum was for: it truly and effectively locked the decision politically" (Kębłowski et al., 2019, p. 974). Kothari et al. (2014) argue that mainstream sustainable development lacks adequate focus on direct democratic governance, where decisions are made by citizens and communities rather than imposed from above. Tallinn's referendum, with a top-down decision presented as a democratic consultation, with a small turnout and conditions designed to produce a predetermined result, is an example of such an absence of direct democratic governance. Hence, the implementation of FFPT in Tallinn is a programme designed without the professional knowledge or genuine community participation needed to address the actual drivers of car dependency.

The consequences of these exclusions are visible in the programme's outcomes. Only 12% of those who missed employment opportunities cited transport cost as the barrier, while 40% cited

distance and travel time, and 31% cited poor connectivity (Cats et al., 2017). Meanwhile, 60% of regular car commuters said they were unwilling to change mode regardless of fare policy (Hess, 2017). The programme addressed affordability, which was the least significant barrier, while ignoring the structural reasons people drive: travel time, connectivity, and a post-Soviet car culture in which automobility became tied to personal and market economy freedoms after decades of state suppression (Hess, 2017).

Who Benefits?

In Estonia, municipalities receive a share of their registered residents' income tax. Tallinn's FFPT was designed to incentivise registration by offering free travel exclusively to those on Tallinn's register (Kębłowski et al., 2019). Interestingly, the €12 million in lost fare revenue after the programme implementation was more than offset by roughly €20 million in new tax income (Hess, 2017). Moreover, city officials pointed to these fiscal returns and rising ridership as evidence that the policy worked without reference to environmental outcomes (Hess, 2017; Gabaldón-Estevan et al., 2019). This reflects what Adams (2008) describes as weak sustainability: the assumption that economic gains can substitute for ecological outcomes, and that natural capital does not need to be maintained independently of overall wealth. The fact that the programme's environmental goals could go entirely unmeasured without undermining its perceived legitimacy emphasises how, despite 'sustainable' objectives, the fiscal logic of the policy fully displaced the ecological one.

Yet while the programme's environmental impact remains uncertain, FFPT delivered genuine social gains within Tallinn. Public transport use rose by 26% among the lowest income group, by 32% among the unemployed, and by 21% among 15 to 19-year-olds. Similarly, the share of residents making no daily trips fell from 18% to 13%, suggesting that the programme generated new mobility for previously immobile populations (Cats et al., 2017). For groups facing transport-related social exclusion, where limited mobility reinforces wider patterns of disadvantage (Lucas, 2012), these are meaningful outcomes. Moreover, public satisfaction with the transport system rose from 16% to 78% between 2012 and 2017 (Gabaldón-Estevan et al., 2019), and 40% of unemployed respondents reported that FFPT had improved their prospects of finding work (Cats et al., 2017). These outcomes show that FFPT functions effectively as social policy.

These gains, however, come at a cost that is visible outside Tallinn's borders. Since FFPT is available only to registered Tallinn residents, the programme created an incentive for people living in surrounding areas to register in Tallinn to access free travel without actually moving there. Between 2012 and 2016, Tallinn gained roughly 25,000 registered residents while surrounding municipalities lost approximately 14,000 (Kębłowski et al., 2019). These residents continued to live in and use the services of their home municipalities, from schools and roads to healthcare and waste collection, while their tax contributions now flowed to Tallinn. Thus, the periphery lost part of its funds while having to provide services for the same number of residents (Kębłowski et al., 2019). Consequently, the result of the FFPT programme is a centre-periphery dynamic in which the capital, already producing over half of Estonia's GDP, draws tax revenue from smaller, less

resourced neighbours. In effect, the residency requirement creates what Caprotti et al. (2015) would recognise as an enclave: a bounded zone whose sustainability benefits are reserved for those inside it, at the cost of those outside. In other words, Tallinn's FFPT policy improves mobility within one municipality by weakening the fiscal capacity of its neighbours and therefore not achieving sustainable development at the regional scale. Rather, it is redistributing its costs outward.

Technology and Environmental Accountability

Along with fare elimination, Tallinn implemented multiple technological changes on January 1, 2013, including launching 70 new buses, 15 new trams, bus priority lanes, and a real-time passenger information system, which collectively increased the capacity and frequency of services by 9.6% (Hess, 2017). Therefore, observed changes in ridership cannot be attributed to the elimination of fares alone and are likely the result of multiple concurrent changes. Furthermore, evaluations found that riders are more sensitive to service frequency improvements than to fare elimination itself (Hess, 2017; Cats et al., 2014; Cervero, 1990). This suggests that the technological and service investments, not fare abolition, were the more important drivers of ridership gains that occurred. This raises a question about the programme's logic: if service quality matters more than price, then the case for fare elimination as a sustainability intervention is weakened at its foundation. The same or greater ridership gains could potentially have been achieved through service improvements alone, without the fiscal and political agenda that fare elimination was built upon.

Alongside fare elimination, the city introduced the ühiskaart contactless smart card. Presented as a modernisation of the transport system, the card's core function was to distinguish registered Tallinn residents, who ride free, from non-residents, who must pay. Beyond the ühiskaart, the city also installed automatic passenger counters and vehicle location tracking systems (Hess, 2017). Together, these tools gave the city the technical capacity to rigorously evaluate the programme's impact on travel behaviour, modal shift, and environmental outcomes. Yet no formal evaluation was ever conducted by the city's transport agency (Hess, 2017), and no reliable data on environmental impacts, such as fuel consumption or air quality, was collected (Gabaldón-Estevan et al., 2019). Meanwhile, only around 30% of riders regularly validated their journeys, rendering ridership data unreliable for planning (Gabaldón-Estevan et al., 2019).

As Mitchell (2002) argues, development discourse transforms political questions into matters of technical management. In Tallinn, the language of transport modernisation, smart cards, real-time tracking, and passenger data framed what was fundamentally a programme of fiscal extraction as a technical improvement in sustainable mobility. The technology gave the programme the appearance of evidence-based transport management without requiring it to actually function as such.

FFPT beyond Tallinn

It is important to note that Tallinn's policy limitations are not unique. Rather, they reflect a consistent global pattern in FFPT implementation. In Tallinn, public transport's mode share rose from 55% to 63%, but walking declined by 40% and car-kilometres increased by 31% (Cats et al., 2017). In Luxembourg, the first country to make all public transport free in 2020, no significant shift from cars to transit was observed (Gillard et al., 2024). Similarly, in Hasselt, Belgium, which operated FFPT from 1996 to 2013, ridership increased tenfold, yet no long-term reduction in car ownership occurred (Cats et al., 2017). As such, even when ridership grows because of FFPT implementation, new riders come overwhelmingly from walking and cycling, not from cars. This happens because the cross-price elasticity between public transport fares and car use is near zero, meaning that making transit free has almost no effect on driving behaviour (Fearnley, 2013). Therefore, as a sustainable development measure, FFPT addresses affordability but not the reasons people drive.

More broadly, this raises the question of what role environmental objectives actually play in FFPT policy. Across Tallinn, Luxembourg, and Hasselt, success is consistently measured through ridership and fiscal figures, not ecological outcomes. Furthermore, a comprehensive evaluation framework for FFPT does not include environmental impact as a standalone evaluation theme, instead focusing on access, operational efficiency, financial health, and community impacts (National Academies, 2023). As such, the environmental and green framing that accompanies FFPT across contexts functions as an empty signifier. City officials use language that is broad enough to give the appearance of progressive action while the underlying priorities remain unchanged (Davidson, 2010). This tension is a reflection of a broader debate within sustainable development between green growth approaches that seek environmental improvement through economic expansion, and degrowth perspectives that argue genuine sustainability requires fundamentally different economic structures (Kothari et al., 2014; Kębłowski, 2023). Tallinn's FFPT programme, with its fiscal growth model and unmeasured environmental claims, reflects the assumptions of the green growth approach rather than challenging them.

Yet, despite the absence of confirmed environmental results, FFPT continues to be adopted across very different political contexts and consistently in proximity to elections. In Tallinn, it launched ten months before municipal elections in which the party that proposed FFPT won (Kębłowski et al., 2019). In Luxembourg, FFPT was promoted before the 2018 election as a tool for modal shift, then approved as a coalition compromise afterwards (Gillard et al., 2024). Most recently, Zohran Mamdani won the 2025 New York City mayoral election with "fast and free buses" as a central campaign pledge (Zohran for NYC, 2025). As evidence shows, FFPT is uniquely suited to electoral politics because it combines two advantages. It offers voters something tangible and cost-free. And once framed as a green or socially progressive measure, it becomes very difficult to oppose. As Reigner (2016) argues, when urban transport policies are framed as sustainable, they become very difficult to oppose because critics risk appearing to side with pollution and inequality. As such, FFPT gives politicians a policy that is both popular to support and dangerous to oppose.

As FFPT spreads globally, what travels between cities is not the evidence of its sustainability outcomes but the appeal of its political formula. This represents what Mitchell (2002) calls the illusion of the model, where politically specific arrangements are stripped of their context and presented as transferable solutions. Tallinn actively promotes itself as a global blueprint for FFPT, hosting international conferences and delegations (Gabaldón-Estevan et al., 2019). Yet the conditions that sustain the programme, including Estonia's residency-based tax system, its post-Soviet demographics, and the Centre Party's political dominance, do not transfer to other places. As a result, other cities adopt the visible policy without these conditions, drawn not by the evidence of its environmental outcomes but by the promise of its electoral appeal.

Conclusion

Ultimately, Tallinn's implementation of fare-free public transport serves as a case study in how the language of sustainable development can be adopted to legitimise a fiscal and electoral project. As this paper has shown, the programme's "greening" approach successfully addressed the immediate barrier of transit affordability, yet it fundamentally failed to challenge car dominance in the city. Similarly, the techno-managerial focus allowed the city to substitute environmental evaluation with metrics of fiscal return and ridership growth.

Importantly, the social gains for disadvantaged groups produced by fare-free public transport in Tallinn are significant and undeniable. Yet they are funded by the same registration mechanism that draws tax revenue from surrounding municipalities. The programme's social achievements and its regional harms are products of the same design and together help to sustain it. Specifically, the social gains ensure public support while the fiscal gains ensure institutional commitment.

At first glance, fare-free public transport in Tallinn presents as an advantageous urban intervention that seemingly aligns social equity with environmental urgency. However, beneath this narrative of transformative change, the Tallinn case shows a deeply pragmatic project aimed at electoral gains. As a first big implementation of the FFPT policy, Tallinn started a trend of its use in municipal elections. In Dunkirk, a mayoral candidate won the 2014 election with FFPT as a central promise. By 2020, FFPT featured in the electoral platforms of candidates in nearly 110 French municipalities alone (Huré et al., 2024). As such, FFPT has become a political tool with global appeal. Whether in Estonia, France, or the United States, the policy is chosen not because it is the most effective way to achieve environmental objectives, but because it is the most effective way to win and maintain power while gaining positive international publicity and appearing to be at the forefront of sustainable development.

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